Yet both India and China continued to entertain perceptions of the other as a threat or a challenge. According to John W. Garver, their mutual threat perceptions have manifested themselves along three dimensions. First, while China is deeply suspicious of India's policy towards Tibet, India's apprehensions have centred on Chinese intervention in an India–Pakistan conflict. Second, India seeks to maintain a dominant position in South Asia, but China has been working to neutralise India's predominance in the region. And third, while China has successfully used Pakistan to maintain a balance of power in South Asia, including through assistance for Pakistan's nuclear weapons and ballistic missile programmes, India has increasingly become a factor in the East Asian equation during the last two decades.[89]

Indian concerns about China in the post–Cold War era have centred on the conventional and nuclear imbalance as well as on the PLA's efforts to gain positional advantage along the Line of Actual Control (LAC). Between 2000 and 2007, "the annual number of violations" of the LAC by the PLA "increased from 90 to 140."[90] This number increased further to 228 in 2010, 411 in 2013, and 334 between January 1 and August 4, 2014.[91] The more serious of these violations have led to diplomatic crises such as those witnessed in Chumar, Ladakh, in 2014; the Doklam standoff in 2017; and the skirmishes in Eastern Ladakh in 2020. Persistent border violations and periodic crises have reinforced India's threat perception vis-à-vis China, especially because these have been occurring against the backdrop of three significant developments during the last two decades: the improvements in road, rail, and air communications infrastructure that China has effected in Tibet;[92] the continued modernisation and reorganisation of the PLA;[93] and the yawning power asymmetry between China and India, most evident in their respective gross